Qualitative Data Analysis and Reporting

What are we looking at? What can we claim? How do we show the path from data to interpretation?

Learning aims

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

01 Distinguish an excerpt, code, category, topic and theme, and explain how they relate.

02 Compare inductive, deductive and abductive reasoning in qualitative analysis.

03 Explain thematic analysis and its varieties, and compare them with content, narrative, discourse, critical discourse and grounded theory analysis.

04 Select an analysis method suited to a research question and justify your choice.

05 Code interview extracts, develop an interpretation supported by evidence and describe the analytic process.

Five terms that do different work

Shared working text · fictional teacher accounts (T1–T3)

Research question: How do teachers build confidence when trying a new feedback tool?

T1	T2	T3
“The workshop showed the buttons, but I did not try it until Mei sat beside me and showed me her class example.”	“I watched the recording twice. I still asked a colleague whether my feedback sounded right.”	“The training gave me a usable routine. I tried it that afternoon and adjusted it after students responded.”

Read T1–T3, then open the cards. Every example comes from this text. Compare the roles of original words, analytic labels and interpretations.

Data excerpt The participant’s or document’s words selected for analysis; keep their context and source ID.	**Text example: “I still asked a colleague whether my feedback sounded right.”** These are T2’s exact words, selected from the full account above.
Code A concise analytic label attached to a meaningful segment.	**Text example: Seeking peer reassurance** This label interprets T2’s action of asking whether the feedback sounded right.
Category A grouping of related codes used to organise material.	**Text example: Sources of support** Groups learning through peer modelling (T1), seeking peer reassurance (T2) and using a training routine (T3).
Topic The subject the material discusses; it can serve as a descriptive heading.	**Text example: Teacher training** Names the subject discussed through the workshop (T1), recording (T2) and training routine (T3).
Theme In interpretive thematic analysis, a patterned meaning organised around a central idea that answers the research question.	**Text example: When formal guidance leaves uncertainty, teachers turn to peers to make the tool usable.** A provisional interpretation of T1 and T2. T3 shows that training can also support use directly; explore the pattern and its limits with fuller data.

Which codes are grouped under “Sources of support”? What does the provisional theme interpret in T1 and T2? How does T3 help define its scope?

Match the analytic role

Shared working text · fictional teacher accounts (T1–T3)

Research question: How do teachers build confidence when trying a new feedback tool?

T1	T2	T3
“The workshop showed the buttons, but I did not try it until Mei sat beside me and showed me her class example.”	“I watched the recording twice. I still asked a colleague whether my feedback sounded right.”	“The training gave me a usable routine. I tried it that afternoon and adjusted it after students responded.”

Each item comes from the analysis of the same text on the previous page. Match its role in this example, check your choices and identify the supporting words in the accounts.

Choose: Data excerpt · Code · Category · Topic · Theme

Teacher training	Your choice: _____
Seeking peer reassurance	Your choice: _____
“I still asked a colleague whether my feedback sounded right.”	Your choice: _____
When formal guidance leaves uncertainty, teachers turn to peers to make the tool usable.	Your choice: _____
Sources of support	Your choice: _____

Trace the matches to the text

Topic: Names the subject discussed through the workshop (T1), recording (T2) and training routine (T3).

Code: This label interprets T2’s action of asking whether the feedback sounded right.

Data excerpt: These are T2’s exact words, selected from the full account above.

Theme: A provisional interpretation of T1 and T2. T3 shows that training can also support use directly; explore the pattern and its limits with fuller data.

Category: Groups learning through peer modelling (T1), seeking peer reassurance (T2) and using a training routine (T3).

Which item preserves original wording? Which items were constructed by the analyst? How would you examine the provisional theme with more interviews?

Where do codes and explanations come from?

Discuss each question before opening the explanation. These logics can inform different qualitative methods.

Inductive · build codes from the data

Data → codes → patterns

What actions or meanings would you label before choosing a theory?

▼ **Compare the logic**

Read closely and create provisional labels for relevant meanings. Compare segments and refine the labels as you examine more material.

Check: Which words support each code? What assumptions shape what you notice?

Deductive · apply a starting framework

Concepts → code definitions → data

What concepts would you define before coding, and what evidence would count for each?

▼ **Compare the logic**

Begin with codes informed by theory, prior research or the research question. Define their boundaries and examine which segments fit. Record material that the framework leaves unexplained.

Check: Can you justify the framework? Have you forced a passage into a code?

Abductive · explain a surprising finding

Puzzle ↔ possible explanations ↔ further evidence

What surprises you? Which competing explanations could account for it?

▼ **Compare the logic**

Move between observations and theoretical ideas to propose a plausible explanation. Compare alternatives and seek evidence that could strengthen, revise or challenge it.

Check: What evidence could separate the alternatives? Keep the explanation provisional.

Hybrid coding combines data-led and prior-concept codes. Abductive reasoning also identifies a puzzle, compares possible explanations and seeks further evidence.

Coding approaches reference ↗ · Timmermans & Tavory (2012) ↗

Three teachers, one question

Question: How do teachers build confidence when trying a new feedback tool?

T1

“The workshop showed the buttons, but I did not try it until Mei sat beside me and showed me her class example.”

T2

“I watched the recording twice. I still asked a colleague whether my feedback sounded right.”

T3

“The training gave me a usable routine. I tried it that afternoon and adjusted it after students responded.”

What is similar? What differs? Which account challenges an easy claim that peer support is always necessary?

Which code earns its place?

For T1’s “Mei sat beside me and showed me her class example”, choose a code that stays close to the action yet contributes to the question.

Technology | **Learning through peer modelling** | **Teachers always need colleagues**

Write another possible code and explain the difference.

Your notes: _____

What would you code in T2? Should T3 receive the same code? Why?

A topic names the area. A theme says something about it.

Topic heading	Candidate interpretive theme
Teacher training Tells us what the material concerns.	**Confidence depends on usable guidance, whether formal or peer-led.** Connects T1-T3 around a central idea while leaving room for different routes.

Which further evidence would most strengthen the candidate theme?

A. The number of times “training” appears

B. More accounts showing how guidance was used and when it was insufficient

C. A quotation from T1 repeated three times

What makes a good theme?

A good theme is data-relevant, clearly defined, meaningful, consistent, and actionable. It captures patterns supported by multiple examples, maintains distinct boundaries from other themes, and reveals insight beyond surface observations.

Does the claim overreach? How would T3 change your wording?

Keep each inference inspectable

Source excerpt **T1, T2, T3**	Meaningful segments **What is happening?**	Initial codes **Short labels**	Categories or patterns **Compare cases**	Candidate theme / account **What does it mean?**	Finding **Claim + evidence + limits**

Use this evidence trail to connect your interpretations to the data. Adapt the analytic steps to your chosen method. Reflexive thematic analysis is recursive; grounded theory analysis, narrative analysis and discourse analysis make different analytic moves.

Which step involves the greatest interpretation, and how would you justify it using the data?

Which kind of answer do you need?

What kinds of messages or practices appear?	What shared meanings organise accounts?	How does something develop through action?	How is experience narrated or a position constructed?
Content analysis	Thematic analysis	Grounded theory	Narrative / discourse analysis

What analytic steps would each question require? What would the resulting finding look like?

Explore qualitative analysis methods

Choose a method. Discuss its guiding questions using the practice text, then reveal the core features to check and refine your reasoning. Compare what each method attends to, how it analyses the material and what it produces.

Meaning and categories	Stories and telling	Language and power	Processes and theory
Thematic analysis Interpret patterns of meaning	**Narrative analysis** Explore how stories are told	**Discourse analysis** Examine language in social action	**Grounded theory analysis** Develop an explanation of a process
Qualitative content analysis Classify meaningful content		**Critical discourse analysis** Examine discourse, power and inequality	

Compare discourse analysis and critical discourse analysis under Language and power. The critical approach explicitly examines power and inequality.

Which method fits the question?

Match all 10 scenarios to the best-fitting method for the stated aim. Methods may be used more than once. Explain your choice before checking; use “Mix order” to shuffle both the scenario list and each answer list for another round.

Methods: Narrative analysis, Grounded theory analysis, Qualitative content analysis, Discourse analysis, Critical discourse analysis, Thematic analysis.

Case 1 How does AI policy wording position teachers as monitors and students as potential rule-breakers?

Your choice: _____

Case 2 What kinds of feedback do teachers describe in 30 interviews? Define categories for feedback purposes and apply clear inclusion rules.

Your choice: _____

Case 3 What kinds of AI use are permitted, discouraged or prohibited in 40 school policies? Develop and apply a category system.

Your choice: _____

Case 4 How do new teachers learn to negotiate assessment expectations? Use iterative interviews, comparisons and theoretically guided sampling to build a process theory.

Your choice: _____

Case 5 What shared meanings underpin teachers’ confidence in giving feedback? Interpret patterns across interviews around central organising ideas.

Your choice: _____

Case 6 How does a new classroom practice become established? Compare incidents, write memos about category relationships and identify further material needed to develop a process explanation.

Your choice: _____

Case 7 How does a teacher tell the story of moving from industry into teaching? Preserve the sequence, turning points and narrative voice.

Your choice: _____

Case 8 How is belonging understood across migrant teachers' accounts? Develop themes connecting acceptance, recognition and everyday exclusion.

Your choice: _____

Case 9 How does admission-policy language legitimise unequal access for migrant pupils? Connect textual choices to institutional inequality.

Your choice: _____

Case 10 How do two teachers narrate returning to work after a career break? Analyse each story's chronology, turning points and self-presentation.

Your choice: _____

Choose two scenarios using the same method. What makes that method appropriate in both? Rewrite one research question so that another method would fit better.

Three readings of one excerpt

Read T1 again. Select a lens and predict what the analyst would look for.

> **T1 · “The workshop showed the buttons, but I did not try it until Mei sat beside me and showed me her class example.”**

Thematic | Content | Discourse

How does peer demonstration contribute to confidence across T1–T3?

Which lens best fits the original research question? What new question would make another lens preferable?

Final practice: read and code the interview

Classroom question: How did working at home during the pandemic reshape everyday working life?

> **Interviewer:** Can you tell me about your experiences with remote work during the COVID-19 pandemic?
>
> **Participant:**
>
> Sure. So, when the pandemic hit, our company quickly transitioned to remote work, and it was quite a significant shift for me. At first, I was excited about the idea of working from home, but it quickly became challenging. One of the biggest issues I faced was the lack of separation between work and personal life. When I was in the office, I had a clear boundary between work and home, but now that I was working from home, it felt like I was always on the clock. It was hard to disconnect and relax.
>
> Additionally, I found communication to be much more difficult. In the office, I could easily walk over to a coworker's desk to ask a question or have a quick chat, but with everyone working remotely, it was harder to get timely responses. Meetings also became a lot less productive. Without the face-to-face interaction, it was challenging to gauge people's reactions and keep everyone engaged.
>
> Another issue was the lack of social interaction. I missed the casual conversations and camaraderie that came with being in the office. It felt isolating at times, especially since I live alone. Overall, while there were some benefits to remote work, such as the flexibility and lack of commute, I found it to be a challenging adjustment.

Interview source: Elizabeth Yardley · Degree Doctor ↗

Final practice: read and code the interview

Classroom question: How did working at home during the pandemic reshape everyday working life?

> Mark each meaningful phrase or sentence. Which label stays close to the material? Where might a segment need more than one code? Keep the full account as context.

Choose two phrases or sentences and note your codes and reasons.

Your notes: _____

Interview source: Elizabeth Yardley · Degree Doctor ↗

One passage, three analytic routes

Do your codes begin with the text or prior concepts? What puzzle arises when flexibility and difficulty stopping work coexist?

▼ 1 · Compare inductive and deductive coding

The deductive column uses an instructor-defined work-life framework set before this demonstration; each cell defines the code's scope. Both columns illustrate analysis of the interview.

Interview phrase	Inductive: text-led label	Deductive: starting code and definition
"it felt like I was always on the clock"	Difficulty ending work	Time boundaries: separation of work and personal time
"it was harder to get timely responses"	Waiting for colleague responses	Coordination: getting information to work together
"it was challenging to gauge people's reactions and keep everyone engaged"	Losing interaction cues	Coordination: sustaining interaction during joint work
"It felt isolating at times, especially since I live alone."	Missing informal company	Social connection: everyday contact and belonging
"the flexibility and lack of commute"	Valuing flexibility and saved travel	Working conditions: practical benefits and constraints

Teaching extensions: the deductive framework and abductive explanations are added for this lesson. Abductive reasoning: Timmermans & Tavory (2012) ↗

One passage, three analytic routes

Do your codes begin with the text or prior concepts? What puzzle arises when flexibility and difficulty stopping work coexist?

▼ 2 · Abduction: explain the puzzle and compare alternatives

Puzzle: The participant values “the flexibility and lack of commute” while feeling “always on the clock”.

Possible explanation: Control over work location may differ from control over when work ends.

Alternative: The difficulty may reflect temporary pandemic arrangements or organisational expectations about responding.

Next evidence: Compare accounts with different working-hour expectations and at different times; seek material that distinguishes the explanations.

Teaching extensions: the deductive framework and abductive explanations are added for this lesson. Abductive reasoning: Timmermans & Tavory (2012) ↗

From initial codes to an analytic account

Practise Braun and Clarke's six phases with the remote-work interview. Discuss each question, then reveal the lesson illustration. Revisit earlier phases as your interpretation develops.

1 · Familiarise

What tensions do you notice before coding?

▼ **Compare the lesson illustration**

Memo: convenience sits alongside difficulty stopping work and reduced everyday contact. Re-read the full source before interpreting isolated lines.

2 · Generate initial codes

Which phrase or sentence supports your label?

▼ **Compare the lesson illustration**

Use the participant's phrases and sentences to justify provisional codes. The preceding table shows one inductive pass. Revisit boundaries and allow several relevant codes on a segment.

3 · Develop candidate themes

What central meaning could connect the codes?

▼ **Compare the lesson illustration**

Flexibility + feeling always on the clock → candidate idea: freedom over workplace can coexist with difficulty ending work. Delayed replies + lost interaction cues + isolation → candidate idea: everyday connection requires more deliberate effort.

One interview supports practice in coding and interpretation. Dataset-wide themes require fuller evidence; the ideas and paragraph here remain provisional teaching illustrations.

Elizabeth Yardley · six-phase guide ↗ · Braun & Clarke (2006) ↗

From initial codes to an analytic account

Practise Braun and Clarke's six phases with the remote-work interview. Discuss each question, then reveal the lesson illustration. Revisit earlier phases as your interpretation develops.

4 · Review and develop

Where does the candidate idea fit, and where might it fail?

▼ **Compare the lesson illustration**

Return to every segment and the fuller dataset. Compare people whose boundaries improved or who welcomed reduced contact. Keep benefits and difficulties visible; revise or split the ideas.

5 · Define and name

What does the theme explain beyond naming a topic?

▼ **Compare the lesson illustration**

Possible name: "A flexible workplace with an unfinished working day". Define its focus on the relation between spatial flexibility and stopping work. Treat this as a candidate requiring broader evidence.

6 · Write the analytic account

Can a reader trace your interpretation to the text?

▼ **Compare the lesson illustration**

Illustrative paragraph: The participant values "the flexibility and lack of commute" while feeling "always on the clock". A possible reading is that flexibility changes where work happens more readily than when it ends. Further accounts are needed to assess that interpretation.

One interview supports practice in coding and interpretation. Dataset-wide themes require fuller evidence; the ideas and paragraph here remain provisional teaching illustrations.

Elizabeth Yardley · six-phase guide ↗ · Braun & Clarke (2006) ↗

Coding terminology follows the method

Qualitative analysis has no universal requirement for “three-level coding”. The table compares coding phases within grounded theory traditions. Thematic, content, narrative and discourse analysis each have their own analytic procedures.

Grounded theory coding terminology: Chun Tie, Birks and Francis (2019), Table 1

Grounded theory tradition	Initial phase	Intermediate phase	Advanced phase
Traditional / classic	Open coding	Selective coding	Theoretical coding
Evolved (Strauss and Corbin)	Open coding	Axial coding	Selective coding
Constructivist (Charmaz)	Initial coding	Focused coding	Theoretical coding

Why do the names differ?

- History: authors and schools have developed distinct vocabularies and procedures.
- Philosophical commitments: traditions differ in how they understand theory generation and the researcher’s role in constructing meaning.
- Analytic tasks: labelling material, selecting significant codes, relating categories and integrating theory involve different work. Read each term alongside the procedure it names.

The columns help comparison; each term’s specific function still depends on the chosen tradition. Even a shared name can have different uses across traditions.

Coding phases, parent-child code hierarchies in software, and code-category-theme groupings describe different aspects of analysis. The six phases of thematic analysis do not imply six code levels. Report your method, define your terms and explain what you actually did.

Ask AI: “Illustrate focused and axial coding using the same interview extract. Explain each procedure’s purpose, tradition and methodological source.” Check its answer against the original methods texts.

Chun Tie, Birks & Francis (2019) · Table 1 · Braun & Clarke (2006)

What is initial coding?

Initial coding is a first analytic pass through the material. Give a short label to a phrase, sentence or meaningful segment relevant to the question. Keep the extract, source and context together so each code has a traceable basis.

1 Select a segment: what is happening, and what action, experience or meaning is expressed?

2 Name it: use concise, specific wording that captures something relevant to the question. A segment can carry more than one code when needed.

3 Compare and revise: examine similar segments and memo your questions and reasons. Refine or split codes as your understanding develops.

See how two excerpts become initial codes

Interview excerpt	Provisional initial code
“it felt like I was always on the clock”	Difficulty ending work
“it was harder to get timely responses”	Waiting for colleague responses

The first code attends to difficulty stopping work; the second attends to waiting during coordination. They preserve different analytic concerns.

Initial codes are provisional analytic choices to revisit against the material. To develop a theme, examine how several codes and extracts support a central meaning.

How would you code “the flexibility and lack of commute”? Which words support your label?

Make your analytic process transparent

1. Name the analytic approach and why it fits the question and data.
2. Describe the data, unit of analysis, analysts and their relevant positioning.
3. Explain the actual steps: coding or another procedure, comparison, revisions and exceptions.
4. Report how each finding is grounded in excerpts, context and a bounded claim.

> Use the target journal's instructions. APA JARS–Qual is a useful reporting prompt across qualitative traditions, not a replacement for method-specific reasoning.

APA JARS–Qual ↗

Take the lesson with you

Commonly used QDA software

NVivo, ATLAS.ti, MAXQDA, or other commercial qualitative data analysis (QDA) software.

Use these tools to organise materials, attach codes, retrieve coded extracts and write memos. Your analytic decisions and interpretations shape the findings.

Download the presentation, including the practice excerpts, guiding questions and method features.

Download lesson PDF

DEDC02 course materials →

Method map →

Thematic analysis

Discuss these questions first

1. What shared meaning could connect several accounts? Which words support your interpretation?
2. How would you move from initial codes to a theme with a central organising idea? How does that differ from a topic heading?
3. How would the researcher’s role and quality criteria change across reflexive, codebook and coding-reliability approaches?

Support your answers with a lesson excerpt, then compare the features below.

Reveal core features and compare your reasoning

- Develops patterns of meaning across a dataset in relation to a research question.
- Themes organise an analytic account; their meaning and development depend on the chosen approach.
- Reflexive, codebook and coding-reliability approaches use different researcher roles and quality criteria.

A family of approaches for developing themes across qualitative material in relation to a research question. Specify the approach and what a theme means within it.

Likely output:A thematic map and an analytic account supported by extracts.

How do I do it?

1. Choose a thematic-analysis approach and state your analytic assumptions.
2. Work through the material, code relevant meanings and develop themes suited to that approach.
3. Explain each theme using extracts, interpretation and the scope of the claim.

What can an output look like?

Classroom illustration: workload, peer support and professional fulfilment are starting topics. A candidate theme could explore how student progress makes demanding work feel worthwhile. Test that idea in a fuller dataset.

Practice-text illustration · candidate ideas to examine

Extract	Possible code	Candidate analytic idea
“feeling overwhelmed”	Managing accumulated demands	Demands compete with creative practice
“all worthwhile”	Finding value in student learning	Student progress helps sustain commitment

Use the illustration to practise analytic judgement. Connect actual claims to the full material and its context.

1 · Compare three families of thematic analysis

Reflexive thematic analysisSituated interpretation

Researchers develop meaning through sustained engagement and reflexivity. Coding evolves; themes are analytic constructions.

In practice: Use analytic memos and dialogue to deepen interpretations. Explain how your positioning shaped decisions.

Quality focus: Coherent interpretation, developed themes and traceable evidence. Agreement statistics have a different analytic rationale.

Codebook thematic analysisA structured coding framework

An explicit coding framework organises analysis, often in applied team research. Templates or matrices can support consistent working procedures.

In practice: Define and revise codes, retain contextual notes and document how team decisions develop. Document code definitions, examples and revisions.

Quality focus:A transparent framework and meaningful interpretation; explain how structure and revision serve the question.

Coding-reliability thematic analysisReproducible coding decisions

A more standardised coding frame supports independent coders applying comparable rules. Reliability is part of the stated analytic logic.

In practice: Define code boundaries, train coders and explain how agreement and disagreements are assessed.

Quality focus: Clear operational decisions and justified reliability procedures, consistent with the underlying assumptions.

Choose an approach that fits the purpose, assumptions about knowledge and researcher role. Keep procedures and quality criteria coherent.

Braun & Clarke · Approaches and quality

2 · Explore analytic choices with the practice texts

Inductive/deductive concerns where concepts start; semantic/latent concerns the level of interpretation. These choices can combine within reflexive TA and should fit your view of knowledge.

Choose a practice text

Teacher practice text

As a new teacher, I find that balancing my workload is challenging. While I enjoy the creativity involved in lesson planning, the constant demands of grading and administrative tasks often leave me feeling overwhelmed. I sometimes wish I had more support from my colleagues to share ideas and resources. Despite these challenges, seeing my students engage and learn makes it all worthwhile.

Summary of student experiences

Many students reported feeling overwhelmed by the amount of coursework assigned during the semester. They expressed that while online resources were helpful, they often struggled to manage their time effectively. Some students mentioned that group projects added to their stress, as coordinating schedules with peers proved challenging. However, a few students noted that collaborating online allowed them to share ideas more freely, which enhanced their learning experience.

Both practice texts are included in full in this slide. The teacher text is first-person; the student text summarises several experiences. Preserve that distinction when analysing them.

teacher / inductive / semantic

Possible codes: enjoying creative planning; feeling overwhelmed by marking and administration; wanting collegial resource-sharing; valuing student learning. These stay close to explicit expressions.

teacher / inductive / latent

Possible interpretation: student progress helps make sustained pressure feel worthwhile. Examine the implied relationship between commitment and demands, and record what further evidence could challenge it.

teacher / deductive / semantic

Start with the analytic concepts demands, resources and fulfilment. Map grading to demands, desired collegial support to resources, and student learning to fulfilment. Record material that the starting frame misses.

teacher / deductive / latent

Use those starting concepts to ask how meaningful rewards might legitimise heavy demands. Treat this as a tentative interpretation; “worthwhile” provides a starting clue, with context and alternative readings still to examine.

students / inductive / semantic

Possible codes: managing coursework load; struggling with time; coordinating peers’ schedules; sharing ideas online. The passage reports experiences collectively, so keep that source form visible.

students / inductive / latent

Possible interpretation: collaboration creates both opportunities and coordination demands. The contrast within the passage suggests an idea to examine in richer student accounts.

students / deductive / semantic

Start with demands, resources and learning opportunities. Classify scheduling as a demand, online resources as support, and idea-sharing as an opportunity; retain the different reported responses.

students / deductive / latent

Ask how digital collaboration redistributes the work of organising learning. The scheduling difficulty and freer idea-sharing support competing readings; neither establishes students' hidden intentions.

Teacher account · inductive · semantic

Examine candidate ideas in a fuller corpus. These short passages support practice in coding and interpretation; a dataset-wide theme needs broader evidence.

Explain your judgement, then compare

"Workload" can name a topic; "feeling overwhelmed by administration" can be a code; "student progress makes demanding work worthwhile" proposes an interpretive idea to test. What material would support or revise it?

Braun & Clarke · Analytic orientations

3 · Work through reflexive thematic analysis

Move back and forth through these six phases as interpretations develop. Re-reading, revising codes and reshaping themes are part of the work.

1Read and revisit

Read the full material, note context and initial questions.

What surprised me, and how did my assumptions shape what I noticed?

2Code meaningful material

Label features relevant to the question; keep extracts and context together.

Which exact words support my code? What other code could be plausible?

3Build candidate patterns

Explore relationships among codes and a possible organising idea.

What meaning connects these codes? Which data differ?

4Challenge the patterns

Review candidate themes against extracts and the whole corpus; revise their boundaries.

Is this idea supported across the relevant material? Where does it fail?

5Clarify the theme claim

Define the central idea, scope and relation to other themes.

What does this theme explain, and how would I name it precisely?

6Present the interpretation

Weave extracts into an analytic account; relate it to the question and relevant literature.

Can a reader follow the evidence for this interpretation and its limits?

In reflexive TA, examine how your positioning shapes interpretation and use analytic dialogue to deepen it. If your aim is to assess coder agreement, explain the analytic logic of your chosen approach.

Braun & Clarke · Six phases of reflexive TA

Methods reference: Braun & Clarke · Understanding TA

Method map →

Qualitative content analysis

Discuss these questions first

1. What segment would you classify: a phrase, sentence or larger unit? What context must you retain?

2. What category definition and inclusion/exclusion rules would let you classify two similar excerpts consistently?

3. Would your categories start from the data or existing concepts? If you counted occurrences, what would the counts tell you and what context would you still need?

Support your answers with a lesson excerpt, then compare the features below.

Reveal core features and compare your reasoning

- Interprets meaningful content through an explicit category system.

- Defines coding units, category boundaries and source-linked examples.

- Conventional, directed and summative approaches differ in how categories or counts enter the analysis.

Systematic interpretation of text through a category system. Conventional analysis develops categories from the material; directed analysis starts with concepts; summative analysis interprets selected counts in context.

Likely output:A category table with definitions and source-linked examples; counts can support an appropriate question.

Practice text for this lesson

> As a new teacher, I find that balancing my workload is challenging. While I enjoy the creativity involved in lesson planning, the constant demands of grading and administrative tasks often leave me feeling overwhelmed. I sometimes wish I had more support from my colleagues to share ideas and resources. Despite these challenges, seeing my students engage and learn makes it all worthwhile.

Use this short account to practise analytic judgement. Other fictional material in the example tables is labelled separately.

How do I do it?

1. Define the question, material and unit to be coded.
2. Develop category definitions, inclusion rules and examples; pilot and revise them.
3. Classify the material, examine relationships and exceptions, and interpret categories in context.

What can an output look like?

In the teacher practice text, “grading” and “administrative tasks” can enter a work-demands category. Define the category boundary and keep the sentence context.

Practice-text illustration · a small category system

Category	Inclusion rule	Practice-text example
Work demands	Tasks requiring time and effort	Grading; administrative tasks
Desired support	Requested assistance or sharing	Ideas and resources from colleagues
Sources of fulfilment	Experiences described as rewarding	Students engage and learn

Use the illustration to practise analytic judgement. Connect actual claims to the full material and its context.

Methods reference: Hsieh & Shannon (2005)

Method map →

Narrative analysis

Discuss these questions first

1. Where does the account begin and end? What sequence and turning point does the teller construct?

2. How does the teller present themselves and address an audience? How does the telling shape the experience?

3. What would be lost if you split the story into isolated topic codes? How would you report its structure and meaning?

Support your answers with a lesson excerpt, then compare the features below.

Reveal core features and compare your reasoning

- Treats the story and its telling as an analytic focus.

- Examines chronology, plot, turning points, voice and self-presentation in context.

- Preserves connections within a narrated journey when developing an interpretation.

Analysis of stories as situated accounts: chronology, plot, turning points, voice and the circumstances of telling can shape meaning.

Likely output:A contextualised account or narrative reconstruction, supported by the teller’s words.

Practice text for this lesson

> As a new teacher, I find that balancing my workload is challenging. While I enjoy the creativity involved in lesson planning, the constant demands of grading and administrative tasks often leave me feeling overwhelmed. I sometimes wish I had more support from my colleagues to share ideas and resources. Despite these challenges, seeing my students engage and learn makes it all worthwhile.

Use this short account to practise analytic judgement. Other fictional material in the example tables is labelled separately.

How do I do it?

1. Identify a story or narrative episode and preserve its surrounding context.
2. Examine sequence, characters, turning points and how the narrator presents events.
3. Interpret how the telling makes sense of experience; explain your chosen narrative approach.

What can an output look like?

The teacher practice paragraph is a short reflective account. A richer career story would be needed to explore transitions, turning points and changing identity in depth.

Fictional illustration · keep a story's sequence visible

Story movement	Narrated event	Possible meaning
Beginning	Leaves industry for teaching	Seeking purposeful work
Turning point	A first difficult lesson	Reconsidering competence
Later reflection	A colleague shares a strategy	Recasting help-seeking as learning

Use the illustration to practise analytic judgement. Connect actual claims to the full material and its context.

Empirical study example

Karalis Noel (2021) · Identity Tensions

Four interviews over a year underpin an account of one former teacher's schooling, preparation, work and departure. Notice how repeated interviews support attention to the sequence and telling of one person's story.

Using this study summary, explain how the material and analytic decisions fit the method. What further evidence would help you assess the interpretation?

Methods reference: Riessman · Narrative Methods

Method map →

Discourse analysis

Discuss these questions first

1. What is the wording doing: justifying an action, claiming expertise or assigning a role?

2. Which contrasts, pronouns or descriptions position the speaker and other people? What textual evidence supports that reading?

3. How would the social or interactional context change your interpretation? How does this differ from classifying what was mentioned?

Support your answers with a lesson excerpt, then compare the features below.

Reveal core features and compare your reasoning

- Examines language as social action and the construction of meanings and positions.

- Analyses specific linguistic choices in their social or interactional context.

- Builds an evidence-based account of what language does, using a stated discourse approach.

A family of approaches examining how language works in context to construct meanings, identities and social action. Specify the tradition and textual focus.

Likely output: An evidence-linked account of how particular linguistic choices accomplish social work.

Practice text for this lesson

> As a new teacher, I find that balancing my workload is challenging. While I enjoy the creativity involved in lesson planning, the constant demands of grading and administrative tasks often leave me feeling overwhelmed. I sometimes wish I had more support from my colleagues to share ideas and resources. Despite these challenges, seeing my students engage and learn makes it all worthwhile.

Use this short account to practise analytic judgement. Other fictional material in the example tables is labelled separately.

How do I do it?

1. Choose an approach and locate texts or interactions in their production and use contexts.
2. Closely examine wording, pronouns, categories, positioning and rhetorical choices.
3. Link textual observations to what language accomplishes in that setting.

What can an output look like?

The teacher's "I sometimes wish" makes a request indirectly; "all worthwhile" positions commitment. These are possible readings to examine in context.

Practice-text illustration · link words to a possible function

Wording	Textual observation	Possible social work
"I sometimes wish"	Tentative expression of need	Softening a request for support
"all worthwhile"	Positive evaluation after challenges	Presenting commitment despite pressure

Use the illustration to practise analytic judgement. Connect actual claims to the full material and its context.

Empirical study example

Balán (2026) · critical discourse analysis · The "skills-first" illusion

A critical discourse analysis of 15 Microsoft communications links textual choices to discourse and social context. The critical discourse analysis card explores this approach.

Using this study summary, explain how the material and analytic decisions fit the method. What further evidence would help you assess the interpretation?

Methods reference: Gee · Discourse analysis

Method map →

Critical discourse analysis

Discuss these questions first

1. Whose interests or authority does the wording support? Whose perspective is absent or marginalised?

2. Which textual choices make an unequal arrangement appear normal or legitimate?

3. What institutional or social evidence would connect that language to power and inequality? How would you avoid claiming more than the evidence supports?

Support your answers with a lesson excerpt, then compare the features below.

Reveal core features and compare your reasoning

- Makes power, ideology and inequality explicit analytic concerns.

- Connects close textual analysis with institutional and social relations.

- Supports critical interpretations with both textual and contextual evidence.

A critical orientation within discourse research. It examines how text and discursive practices legitimise, reproduce or challenge unequal social relations.

Likely output: An argument linking specific textual evidence, discursive practices and social structures.

Practice text for this lesson

> As a new teacher, I find that balancing my workload is challenging. While I enjoy the creativity involved in lesson planning, the constant demands of grading and administrative tasks often leave me feeling overwhelmed. I sometimes wish I had more support from my colleagues to share ideas and resources. Despite these challenges, seeing my students engage and learn makes it all worthwhile.

Use this short account to practise analytic judgement. Other fictional material in the example tables is labelled separately.

How do I do it?

1. Identify the social problem, institutional context and critical framework.

2. Analyse textual choices and how texts are produced, circulated and taken up.

3. Connect the textual evidence to power and inequality; consider alternative interpretations.

What can an output look like?

A fictional policy calling learners “future workforce assets” could position education around productivity. Examine who gains authority and which educational purposes are absent.

Fictional policy illustration · trace a critical argument

Wording	Representation	Critical question
“future workforce assets”	Learners framed as economic resources	Which educational purposes are privileged?
“every learner must remain competitive”	Obligation placed on individuals	How is responsibility distributed?

Use the illustration to practise analytic judgement. Connect actual claims to the full material and its context.

Empirical study example

Balán (2026) · The “skills-first” illusion

A corpus of 15 Microsoft AI-skilling communications is examined through Fairclough’s critical discourse approach, connecting textual choices with discourse and social context.

Using this study summary, explain how the material and analytic decisions fit the method. What further evidence would help you assess the interpretation?

Methods reference: Balán (2026) · empirical application of Fairclough’s model

Method map →

Grounded theory analysis

Discuss these questions first

1. What action or process could you investigate in the account? How might one action lead to another?

2. What would you compare next, and whom would you sample to clarify an emerging category?

3. What relationships between categories would explain the process? What evidence would make you revise that explanation?

Support your answers with a lesson excerpt, then compare the features below.

Reveal core features and compare your reasoning

- Develops an explanatory theory of a process through iterative analysis and data collection.

- Uses constant comparison, analytic memos and theoretical sampling to develop categories and their relationships.

- States the grounded-theory tradition and follows its analytic logic.

An analytic approach within grounded theory for developing explanatory categories and their relationships. Constant comparison, memo writing and theoretical sampling support theory development.

Likely output:A substantive theory or process model with evidence for relationships between categories.

Practice text for this lesson

> As a new teacher, I find that balancing my workload is challenging. While I enjoy the creativity involved in lesson planning, the constant demands of grading and administrative tasks often leave me feeling overwhelmed. I sometimes wish I had more support from my colleagues to share ideas and resources. Despite these challenges, seeing my students engage and learn makes it all worthwhile.

Use this short account to practise analytic judgement. Other fictional material in the example tables is labelled separately.

How do I do it?

1. Compare incidents and develop analytic codes while collecting data.

2. Write memos about categories, their properties and relationships; let these guide further sampling.

3. Integrate the categories into an explanatory theory and examine its adequacy.

Grounded-theory traditions use different coding language: constructivist work often uses initial and focused coding; Straussian work can use open, axial and selective coding. State the approach you follow.

What can an output look like?

The teacher practice text could suggest an initial question about sustaining commitment under workload pressure. A theory would require iterative data collection and comparison.

Fictional illustration · proposed relationships to test

Condition	Action / interaction	Proposed consequence
Work demands intensify	Seeking collegial support	Accessing workable routines
Usable guidance becomes available	Trying and adapting routines	Sustaining participation
Support remains inaccessible	Continuing alone	Prolonged strain

Use the illustration to practise analytic judgement. Connect actual claims to the full material and its context.

Empirical study example

Brown, Howard & Walsh (2022) · Building Trauma Informed Teachers

23 interviews and a theoretical-sampling focus group with seven interviewees. Notice that analysis informs further sampling, supporting category development and an explanatory theory.

Using this study summary, explain how the material and analytic decisions fit the method. What further evidence would help you assess the interpretation?

Methods reference: Charmaz · Constructing Grounded Theory

Method selection: compare your reasoning

Case 1: Discourse analysis

The aim is to examine how language constructs roles and power relations; listing policy topics would miss this work.

Case 2: Qualitative content analysis

Content analysis builds and applies a category system to classify meaningful material, preserving definitions and context.

Case 3: Qualitative content analysis

Content analysis classifies meaningful content systematically. The intended output is a category system with clear definitions and examples.

Case 4: Grounded theory analysis

Grounded theory develops relationships between categories into an explanatory theory; ongoing analysis guides what data to seek next.

Case 5: Thematic analysis

Thematic analysis develops patterns of shared meaning around central organising ideas. A theme explains a pattern through a central organising idea.

Case 6: Grounded theory analysis

Grounded theory analysis develops relationships between categories through constant comparison and memo writing, with further material guided by the developing explanation.

Case 7: Narrative analysis

Narrative analysis examines how a story is organised and told over time. Isolating quotations into topics could lose its sequence and plot.

Case 8: Thematic analysis

The aim is to interpret shared meanings across accounts. Thematic analysis can connect these meanings without requiring a new process theory.

Case 9: Critical discourse analysis

A critical approach within discourse analysis explicitly connects textual choices to power and institutional inequality.

Case 10: Narrative analysis

Narrative analysis attends to the narrated journey, including chronology, turning points and how the teller presents events.